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A New Dawn

At the time of independence, there were less than 100 kilometres of roads, three schools with fifty students, one hospital and three dispensaries in Arunachal Pradesh! This in a state that is twice the size of Switzerland! There are twenty-six major tribes and over 100 sub-tribes in the state. Traditionally, they used to trade with people in the Assam plains. They very rarely had any dealings with the Tibetans across the Himalayas except the Monpa, Memba, Khamba, Mishmi and Sherdukpen tribes in the north. The people of Arunachal are fiercely patriotic and nationalistic and take umbrage at the Chinese laying claims over areas of their state. During my tenure I have witnessed a number of events where the people of Arunachal have expressed their anti-Chinese feelings. The youth organizations have held a 'dharna' at 'Jantar Mantar' in New Delhi, taken a motorcycle rally with anti-China placards upto Bumla on the border, banned Chinese goods in the local markets and burnt the effigies of Chinese prime minister as a protest against the issue of stapled visas being given to people from Arunachal Pradesh.

Arunachal Pradesh is the only state in the northeast where Hindi is universally spoken. In fact, it has become a link language amongst the people as most Arunachalees do not understand the language or dialect spoken by tribes other than their own. The state has come a long way now, with the focus on vitally important infrastructure development. A greenfield airport will come up at Itanagar, and across the state, eight subsidiary airfields are being upgraded and extended for short-take-off-and-landing aircraft. As mentioned earlier, a trans-Arunachal highway is under construction, which will enhance connectivity manifold by joining the major valleys laterally